Answering 10-Mark Questions

Exam code: 9BS0

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How do I answer an Edexcel A level Business 10-mark question?

- These questions appear in all three exam papers
- Two marks are available for knowledge, two for application, three for analysis and three for evaluation.

Suggested structure

- Key business skills are highlighted

Knowledge Application Analysis Evaluation

Step 1
• Start off with a **definition of the key term** in the question stem   ○ This will secure some Level 1 knowledge marks and can help you focus your response
Just-in-time involves stock arriving in warehouses immediately before distribution. A definition shows good knowledge
Step 2

• In the next paragraph, you should start your analysis by **making a strong point**
  ○ Support it with some relevant **context** from the stimulus material
  ▪ Quoting some data, including a calculation, or remarking on a key business feature or trend are good ways to do this
  ○ Develop a chain of reasoning that develops the point logically. The X→Y→Z approach is a good way to build a coherent chain:
  ▪ E.g. X leads to Y which results in Z ***or*** X and Y lead to Z

Help me understand

Stuck on something?
Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.
Got it

leads to Y_1 and/or Y_2, which results in Z **or** X leads to Y, which results in Z_1 and/or Z_2

After production, fashion items are promptly shipped to Zara stores across Europe. This means that items purchased from the brand have a level of exclusivity. Wearers of Zara clothes are unlikely to see them being worn by others, as is often the case with other brands. Zara can therefore charge a relatively high mark-up on its clothing. This helps to maximise Zara's profits, a key measure of success.

A clear, correct point

Several uses of the context in the paragraph

A strong XYZ chain of reasoning

Step 3

- In the next paragraph, you need to show balance by **providing a counterpoint**
  - Make a logical, relevant counterpoint
  - Make sure that it is relevant to the question stem
  - A further chain of XYZ reasoning, with context, is also required

However, selling very limited volumes of products may disappoint fashion-conscious customers. If clothing has been worn by a celebrity or features in fashion magazines it is likely to sell-out very quickly. Some customers may prefer to shop with rivals such as New Look whose stock levels are more predictable. As a result, Zara's sales may not be as high as they could otherwise be.

A clear, correct counterpoint

A well-contextualised chain of reasoning

Another strong XYZ chain of reasoning which provides balance

Step 4

- Repeat steps two and three with a further point and counterpoint

Just-in-time minimises the value of stock held in storage. This can help to reduce Zara's insurance costs. Zara has suffered fires within its warehouses in recent years, so insurance costs may be quite high. Zara is also less likely to suffer supply chain disruption. Stock will be moving to stores rather than being held in a vulnerable central storage location. Loss of sales such as those suffered following the Barnsley fire in 2014 would therefore be unlikely.

However, stock that is 'on the move' will also need adequate protection. Careful monitoring of logistics will be vital and security will be important to avoid pilferage once the stock is in transit. If delivery delays occur, or if stock is missing, Zara stores may run out the most popular fashion items. This would be disastrous for its 'fast fashion' reputation, as well as for sales.

A second, correct point

Effective use of context throughout this paragraph

Reasoning, though it could be linked more convincingly

Another correct counterpoint

A much stronger XYZ chain, with well-chosen context

Step 5

In the final paragraph, you need to **make a supported judgement**

strength and relevance

- A decision is required, along with the main reasons for your choice, such as:
  - Are there any context-specific reasons for your choice?
  - Do you have all of the information required?
  - Does your answer depend on any factors?
  - Might your decision be different in the long term?

Overall, just-in-time has allowed Zara to stand out as a business that delivers the most up-to-date fashions before its rivals. It is a favourite of fashion journalists as the most on-trend items are sold in stores. This means that customers visit the website or shops much more frequently than those of other brands such as New Look. Its sales volumes are thus very high and the business is very profitable. It could be argued, though, that factors other than just-in-time have contributed to Zara's success. It operates on a very large scale across 50 countries. It is therefore likely to enjoy managerial and technical economies of scale. Although bulk buying economies are unlikely, it may have been able to develop very strong relationships with suppliers. All of this will minimise costs and help to ensure its success.

Some judgement

Contextualised reasoning for the judgement

Balance now provided to the judgement, showing good knowledge, a chain of reasoning and relevant context

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